A Parent's Guide to Education in Alberta

Scripts, not sentiment. What the school has to do, what to say when it doesn't, and where to go next.

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Foreword: the information every parent wished they had from the beginning

A gap found and filled.

There is a moment every parent in this book knows.

You're sitting in a small chair at a small table. Someone slides a document across to you. It has your child's name on it and a word you've never heard, and everyone in the room seems to already know what it means. You nod. You sign where they point. You go home and wonder what you just agreed to.

Nobody told you what that document was supposed to contain. Nobody told you that you could take it home and read it first. Nobody told you there were rules, written down, that the school had to follow, or where to find them, or what to say when the answer was "it's ongoing."

That's the gap.

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I fell into it. Years of my children's schooling went into it before I understood what I was standing in. I asked the questions I knew how to ask, and I got answers that sounded like answers and weren't. I thought the problem was me. I thought I was asking too much, or asking wrong.

I wasn't. I just didn't have the information. Almost nobody does, at the start.

It exists. It's scattered across an Act, a set of regulations, standards from 2004, a ministry guide from 2006, a new framework, and your own division's policy manual, most of which you'll never be shown. The only parents who put it together are the ones who fight long enough to find it, piece by piece, at kitchen tables, at two in the morning. By then, their children have lost the years it took.

I did the fighting. I read the Act. I read the regulations. I compared one document to another until the gaps between them were the only thing I could see. And somewhere in all of that, I realized the thing I was building for my own family was the thing every family needed on day one.

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So this is it. The information every parent wished they had from the beginning, in one place, in plain words.

It tells you what the rules say and how binding they are. It tells you what to say out loud, in under forty words, when your hands are shaking. It tells you exactly what to ask for in writing, and what to do when you don't get it. It's organized by what you're hearing, not by what the system calls it, because when someone is talking at you across that small table, you don't have time to look up "Grade Level of Achievement." You have time to find the words you just heard.

It isn't angry. That's on purpose. A book that argues can be argued with. A book that tells you what the rule says and where it's written can only be answered.

It won't fix the system. But it closes the gap between what a school is required to do and what a parent knows to ask for. That gap is where most of us lost our first years.

You don't have to lose yours.

Chantal 🌹

A note on the stories in this book

The situations and phrases in these pages come from my own family's years in Alberta schools and from the parents who write to The Alberta Disability System Breakdown. Every name, school, place, date, grade, score and diagnosis has been removed. The phrases under "You might be hearing" are written the way any parent in any division might hear them, not as quotes from any one person. Nothing in this book says why anyone did anything. It records what was said and what the documents show.

The one thing to know about this book

This book is information, not legal advice. If you need advice about your own situation, get it from someone qualified to give it.

How to use this book

Find the page by what you're hearing. You don't need to know what the system calls your problem. Each chapter opens with "Turn here when you're hearing": the words staff say, and the entry that answers them. The deflection dictionary at the back lists them all.

Every entry has the same shape. Once you've used one, you can use them all.

- **You might be hearing:** the words that sent you here.
- **What's going on:** what it means, in plain words.
- **What the rules say:** the rule, where it comes from, and how binding it is.
- **Say this:** what to say out loud, in under 40 words.
- **Ask for this in writing:** the exact thing to request afterwards, with a date in it.
- **If you don't get it:** your next step, and the entry where it lives.
- **Write this down:** one line for your notebook.
- **Your division may also have:** where your own division's rules may add to the province's.

Entries are numbered, not paged. 4.7 is the seventh entry in chapter 4. Numbers never change between editions, so "turn to 4.7" means the same thing in every copy. An entry that stops being true is retired, not deleted, and points you to its replacement.

How hard is the rule? Every "What the rules say" names the kind of rule it is. In order of strength:

- **Law:** an Act, like the Education Act. Binding.
- **Regulation:** rules made under an Act. Binding.
- **Ministerial order or standard:** rules the Minister makes under the Education Act, like the Standards for Special Education. Binding on school boards.
- **Provincial policy and guidance:** documents like the Guide to Education, the 2006 IPP resource and the Student Support Policy Framework. They say what the province expects. Where they say "should", they are guidance, not law, and this book says so.
- **Division policy:** your division's own administrative procedures. Binding on its staff.
- **School practice:** "how we do it here". Not a rule unless it's written in one of the above.

Where no rule exists, the entry says so plainly. That is a finding too.

Live pages. Each chapter will have a live web page where corrections go up first. The address is printed under the chapter title.

The phone card

Cut this out or take a photo of it.

Fill in your own

- School office:
- Principal:
- Learning support or inclusive education lead at the school:
- Division student services (or inclusive education) contact:
- Superintendent's office:
- Your ward trustee:
- Your child's doctor:
- FSCD worker (if you have one):

Province

- Alberta Education and Childcare, general inquiries: 780-427-7219. Toll-free in Alberta: dial 310-0000, then the number.
- Alberta Supports (includes FSCD): 1-877-644-9992, Monday to Friday 7:30 am to 8 pm.
- Office of the Information and Privacy Commissioner (access to records, privacy): 780-422-6860, toll-free 1-888-878-4044.
- Alberta Human Rights Commission, confidential inquiry line: 780-427-7661.
- Alberta Teaching Profession Commission (complaints about a teacher's or school leader's conduct or competence): online complaint form at alberta.ca. See chapter 12 before you use it.

Health and crisis, any time day or night

- Emergency: 911
- Health Link: 811
- Mental Health Help Line: 1-877-303-2642
- Kids Help Phone: 1-800-668-6868
- Suicide Crisis Helpline: 988
- 211 Alberta (community services): 211

Ten things to know on day one

1. **Support starts with a decision.** The board decides whether your child needs specialized supports and services. Once it has, your child is entitled to them. Ask whether that decision has been made, and get the answer in writing. See 4.1 and 2.2.
2. **Every identified student gets an IPP, and Alberta says what goes in it.** The form is the division's. The contents are not. See 4.2.
3. **Your signature is consent, not a receipt.** You can read the plan first, and you can withdraw consent later. See 4.6.
4. **"Ongoing" is not a date.** Alberta's 2006 IPP resource says IPP reviews line up with the school's reporting periods: "These are generally scheduled three to four times per year." It adds that vague terms such as "ongoing" "do not adequately describe what a student has achieved" (chapter 1, page 14). That's guidance, not law. See 4.4.
5. **If it isn't written down, it didn't happen.** Follow every meeting and phone call with a short email saying what was agreed, by whom, by when. See 10.13 and letter L.7.
6. **You can see your child's student record and get a copy.** The IPP and every amendment to it must be on it. See 3.3 and 11.5.
7. **Keep your registration form, every year.** It's the only copy you control of what you told the school. See 3.2.
8. **We read the whole Education Act and found no section that lets a school put one child on a shortened day on its own say-so.** A child can lawfully miss part of a day through a suspension from class periods (5 school days at most, with a written report), an excusal the parent asks for, or a ministerial exemption order. Ask which section they are relying on, and get it in writing. See 8.8 and 2.9.
9. **A failure to decide is a decision you can appeal.** Know the ladder and the deadlines before you need them. See 12.5 and 12.15.
10. **At 18, your rights pass to your child.** Start planning at 16. See 14.12 and 16.10.